

L2B: Orders of Growth

CS1101S: Programming Methodology

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21st August, 2026

Outline

Announcements

Tree Recursion (Textbook 1.2.2)

Orders of Growth (Textbook 1.2.3)

Calendars & Absence Policy

New Calendars

Now on Canvas: **Lectures and Events** calendar and **Timelines** calendar — subscribe to stay in sync!

Simplified Absence Policy

Allowed without penalty, throughout the semester:

- ▶ 1 absence in Studios
- ▶ 1 absence in Reflections
- ▶ 2 absences in Lectures
- ▶ 1 absence in RA/PA

E.g. for Studios: we expect **10 non-zero Studio XP** out of 11 Studios for full attendance credit.

Keep your MCs — only submit them at the end of semester if you exceed the allowance above.

Studio Attendance and Participation

- ▶ Attendance and Participation (5% of CS1101S)
 - Studios are small communities of learners; your presence in the sessions is needed to be an effective member
 - 3% for Studio attendance
 - 2% for Studio participation; Avengers assess your participation, based on effort
 - The ideal Studio member prepares well for the meetings, contributes by answering any questions thoughtfully, asks good questions, and tries to help classmates in mastering the material
- ▶ Studio Performance XP
 - Maximal 500 XP per Studio session
 - Here is where you can shine, by helping others, contributing to discussions, going the extra mile

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Fibonacci Numbers

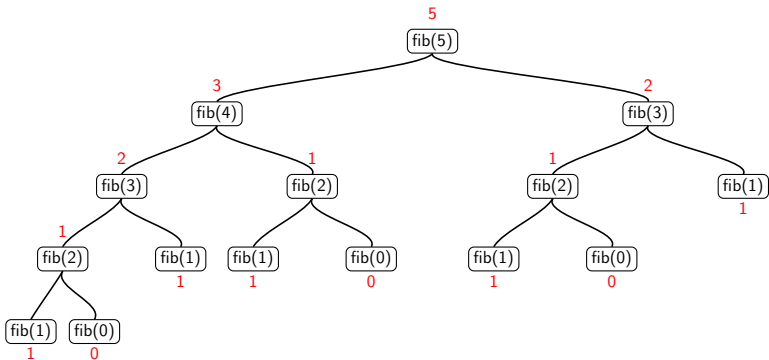
- ▶ Fibonacci sequence
 - 0, 1, 1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 13, 21, ...
 - Each number is the sum of the previous two
- ▶ Fibonacci function $F(n)$, such that $F(0) = 0$, $F(1) = 1$, $F(2) = 1$, $F(3) = 2$, $F(4) = 3$, and so on
- ▶ Our attempt to implement $F(n)$ in Python:

```
def fib(n):  
    return n if n <= 1 else fib(n - 1) + fib(n - 2)
```

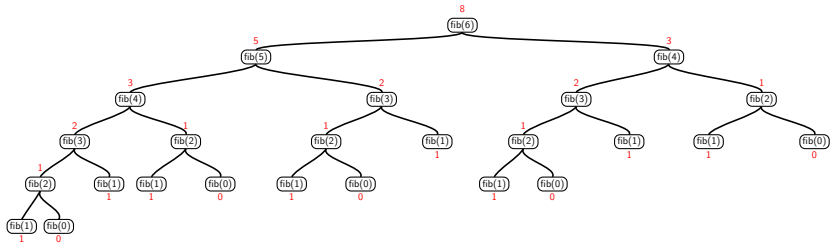


Evaluating fib(5)

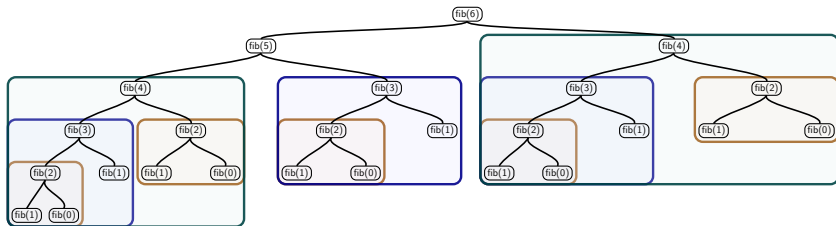
```
def fib(n):  
    return n if n <= 1 else fib(n - 1) + fib(n - 2)
```



Evaluating fib(6)



Evaluating fib(6)



Example: Computing $F(n)$ using $\text{fib}(n)$

- ▶ Number of leaves in the recursion tree for $\text{fib}(n)$ is $F(n + 1)$
 - $\text{fib}(10)$ needs to visit $F(11) = 89$ leaves
 - $\text{fib}(20)$ needs to visit $F(21) = 10946$ leaves
 - $\text{fib}(40)$ needs to visit $F(41) = 165580141$ leaves
 - $\text{fib}(100)$ needs to visit $F(101) = 573147844013817084101$ leaves

Time for Evaluating fib(n)

- ▶ Time for exploring the tree grows with size of tree
- ▶ Tree for fib(n) has $F(n + 1)$ leaves, where

- $F(n) = \left\lfloor \frac{\varphi^n}{\sqrt{5}} + \frac{1}{2} \right\rfloor$, and $\varphi = \frac{1 + \sqrt{5}}{2}$

Can we write an efficient iterative function that computes $F(n)$?

Fibonacci Numbers (iterative version)

```
def fib(n):  
    return fib_iter(1, 0, n)  
  
def fib_iter(a, b, count):  
    return b if count == 0 else fib_iter(a + b, a, count - 1)
```

► How efficient is this program?

Wait. What does it even mean to be efficient?

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A Tale of Two Programmers



Prof Martin

writes beautiful, elegant code



Prof Sanka

writes ruthlessly efficient code

Both are asked to solve the *same* problem.

How Do We Compare Their Programs?

- ▶ Readability
- ▶ Style
- ▶ Elegance
- ▶ ...

Wait, how do we compare programs?

Today: two measurable dimensions

Time: how long does the program run

Space: how much memory does it need

Recall the Factorial Function

► Recursive definition

- $n! = 1$ if $n = 1$
- $= n(n - 1)!$ if $n > 1$

► In Python:

```
def factorial(n):  
    return 1 if n == 1 else n * factorial(n - 1)
```

► Example call:

```
print(factorial(4))
```



Time for Calculating factorial(n)

factorial(4)

4 * factorial(3)

4 * (3 * factorial(2))

4 * (3 * (2 * factorial(1)))

4 * (3 * (2 * 1))

4 * (3 * 2)

4 * 6

24

Time for Calculating factorial(n): Observation

Observation

Number of operations grows linearly proportional to n

Space for Calculating factorial(n)

factorial(4)

4 * factorial(3)

4 * (3 * factorial(2))

4 * (3 * (2 * factorial(1)))

4 * (3 * (2 * 1))

4 * (3 * 2)

4 * 6

24

Space for Calculating factorial(n): Observation

Observation

Number of deferred operations grows linearly proportional to n

Doubling the Argument of factorial ($n = 2$)

```
factorial(2)  
2 * factorial(1)  
2 * 1  
2
```

Doubling the Argument of factorial ($n = 4$)

factorial(4)

4 * factorial(3)

4 * (3 * factorial(2))

4 * (3 * (2 * factorial(1)))

4 * (3 * (2 * 1))

4 * (3 * 2)

4 * 6

24

Doubling the Argument of factorial: Observation

Time

The number of steps “roughly” doubles. The factorial function runs in a time (linearly) proportional to the argument n .

Space

The number of deferred operations also “roughly” doubles. It has a space requirement (linearly) proportional to the argument n .

Orders of Growth

- ▶ Linear growth
 - The factorial function runs in a time (linearly) proportional to the argument n
- ▶ Exponential growth
 - The fib function runs in a time that grows exponentially with the argument n

What exactly do we mean by the above?

Purpose

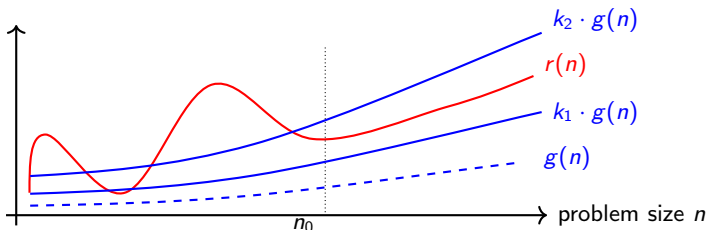
- ▶ Rough measure
 - We are interested in a rough measure of resources used by a computational process, with respect to the problem size
- ▶ Abstraction
 - “Order of growth” is an abstraction technique
 - We decide to ignore details that we deem irrelevant
 - Examples: the processor speed of the computer, the programming environment, the programming language, or minor differences in programming style

The Resource Function

- ▶ For a program P solving a problem of size n , let $r(n)$ denote the amount of a *resource* (time or space) that P needs
- ▶ Recall Prof Martin and Prof Sanka: both write a program for the *same* problem
- ▶ Plug in Martin's program: $r(n)$ tells us its resource use
- ▶ Plug in Sanka's program instead: $r(n)$ now tells us Sanka's program's resource use, same symbol, different program

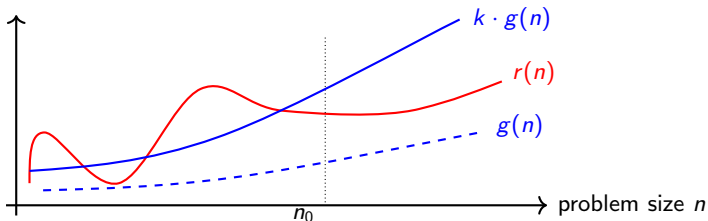
The Θ (“Big Theta”) Notation

- ▶ Let n denote the size of the problem, and let $r(n)$ denote the resource needed solving the problem of size n
- ▶ Definition: The function r has order of growth $\Theta(g(n))$ if there are positive constants k_1 and k_2 and a number n_0 such that $k_1 \times g(n) \leq r(n) \leq k_2 \times g(n)$ for all $n > n_0$



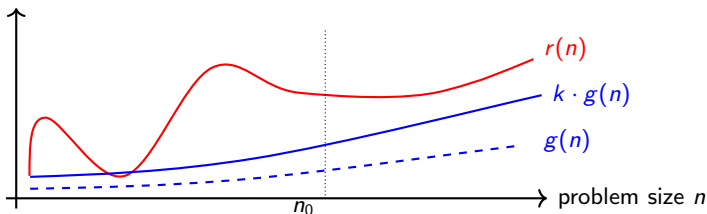
The Big-O (“Big Oh”) Notation

- ▶ Let n denote the size of the problem, and let $r(n)$ denote the resource needed solving the problem of size n
- ▶ Definition: The function r has order of growth $O(g(n))$ if there is a positive constant k and a number n_0 such that $r(n) \leq k \times g(n)$ for all $n > n_0$



The Ω (“Big Omega”) Notation

- ▶ Let n denote the size of the problem, and let $r(n)$ denote the resource needed solving the problem of size n
- ▶ Definition: The function r has order of growth $\Omega(g(n))$ if there is a positive constant k and a number n_0 such that $k \times g(n) \leq r(n)$ for all $n > n_0$



Do Constants Matter?

- ▶ Let's say r has order of growth $\Theta(n^2)$
- ▶ Does r also have order of growth $\Theta(0.5n^2)$?
- ▶ Constants don't matter
 - Because we can freely choose k, k_1, k_2

Do Minor Terms Matter?

- ▶ Let's say r has order of growth $O(n^2)$
- ▶ Does r also have order of growth $O(n^2 + 40n - 5)$?
- ▶ Minor terms don't matter
 - Because we can adjust n_0 , k , k_1 , k_2 such that the minor terms are overruled

Some Common $g(n)$

- ▶ $\log n$
- ▶ n
- ▶ $n \log n$
- ▶ n^2
- ▶ n^3
- ▶ 2^n

Growing Pains

It is now time (or space) to go to the Source Academy!

Apologies, I am running out of jokes here already and we are only in week 2!

Look for Check-In I2B in the Source Academy!

(No need to finalize your Check-In submission. Please stop working as soon as we call time!)

Example Orders of Growth

► Linear time

- The factorial function runs in a time that has order of growth $\Theta(n)$, where n is the function argument
- Can we say its order of growth is $O(n)$?
- Can we say its order of growth is $O(n^2)$?

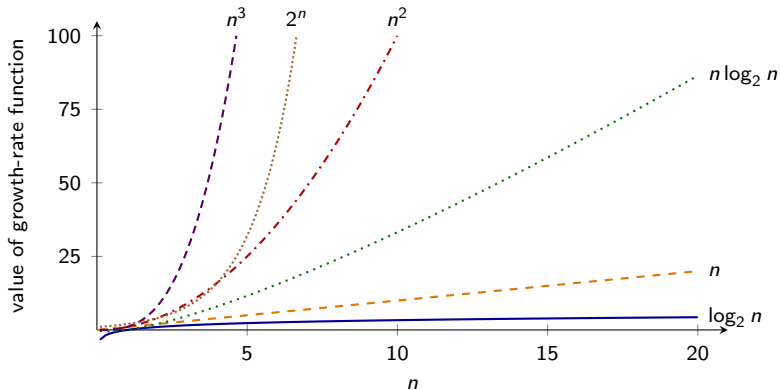
► Exponential time

- The fib function runs in a time that has order of growth $\Theta(\varphi^n)$, where n is the function argument and $\varphi = \frac{1+\sqrt{5}}{2} \approx 1.618$
- Can we say its order of growth is $O(2^n)$?

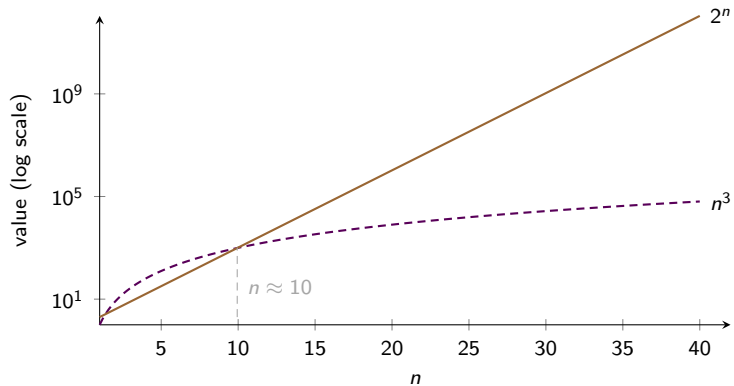
Comparing Orders of Growth: Table

Function	n					
	10	100	1,000	10,000	100,000	1,000,000
1	1	1	1	1	1	1
$\log_2 n$	3	6	9	13	16	19
n	10	10^2	10^3	10^4	10^5	10^6
$n \log_2 n$	30	664	9,965	10^5	10^6	10^7
n^2	10^2	10^4	10^6	10^8	10^{10}	10^{12}
n^3	10^3	10^6	10^9	10^{12}	10^{15}	10^{18}
2^n	10^3	10^{30}	10^{301}	$10^{3,010}$	$10^{30,103}$	$10^{301,030}$

Comparing Orders of Growth: Graph

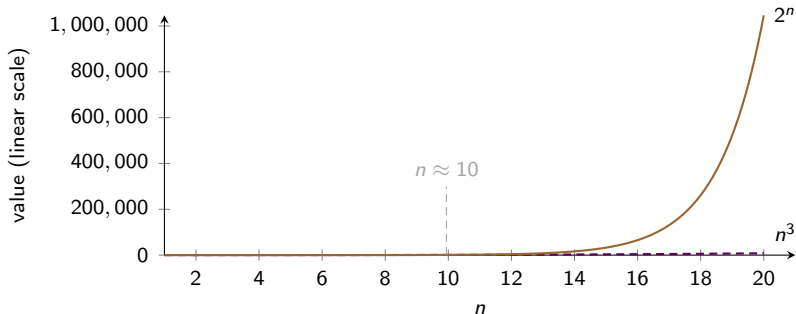


Comparing Orders of Growth: n^3 vs 2^n



They cross around $n \approx 10$ and past that, 2^n pulls away from n^3 ever faster, and the gap grows without bound.

n^3 vs 2^n : Linear Scale



On a linear scale, n^3 all but disappears next to 2^n once n grows a little past the crossover this is exactly why we use order of growth instead of trying to compare raw numbers.

How to Calculate “Big Oh/Theta/Omega”

- ▶ Topic of Algorithm Analysis (CS3230)
- ▶ For us:
 - Identify the basic computational steps
 - Try a few small values
 - Extrapolate
 - Watch out for “worst case” scenarios
 - Pick the *tightest* bound

Why tightest?

It's true that Usain Bolt can run 100m in under 10 *minutes*... but that's not meaningful. What we actually care about is that he can do it in under 10 *seconds*.

Summary

- ▶ Resources for computational processes: time and space
- ▶ Big Theta, Big Oh, Big Omega
 - Provide abstractions or “rough” measures of resources used with respect to problem size